

Australia Chair Daily Brief

AUSTRALIA · NEW ZEALAND · THE PACIFIC ISLANDS

Wednesday, September 9, 2026

RE: Solomons Opposition alleges Australian interference · Canberra publishes Naoero NZYQ deal · algorithm opt-out bill lands · China pushes Pacific policing · NZDF seeks closer Australian ties

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ASX 200 **8,903** -0.84% AUD/USD **0.7226** +0.87% NZX 50 **13,793** -0.99% NZD/USD **0.5856** +0.09%
BRENT **99.33** +3.99%

TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Solomon Islands' Opposition accused Australia of foreign interference over a leaked text message to Deputy Prime Minister Francis Sade, days after a no-confidence motion lapsed and Canberra agreed in principle to a billion-dollar treaty package.
- 2 Canberra published the terms of its NZYQ deportation agreement with Naoero covering more than 350 people, with Green Party senator David Shoebridge saying the government still withholds the separate memorandum setting up the financial arrangement.
- 3 China called for more practical results with Pacific Island countries on police capacity building, Xinhua reported, as Fiji's immigration ministry insisted Australia will get no backdoor access to its new border system.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Solomon Islands Opposition alleges Australian interference as treaty deal lands

Solomon Islands' Opposition says a leaked message between the Australian High Commission and Deputy Prime Minister Francis Sade appeared to show Australian funding being used to influence the outcome of a no-confidence motion against the prime minister. Sade rejected the claim, saying the text was an update on successful treaty negotiations and should not be used as political ammunition. The motion was withdrawn just as negotiations wrapped up, with Australia agreeing in principle to a billion-dollar package. Lowy Institute research fellow Oliver Nobetau said the common thread across recent bilateral agreements is language on denying strategic access to third parties.

per ABC Pacific: "Solomon Islands Opposition accuses Australia of foreign interference" · also Sydney Morning Herald (Matthew Knott)

AU-POLITICS

Albanese unveils algorithm opt-out under Digital Duty of Care bill

Anthony Albanese confirmed Australians will be able to choose between existing recommendation algorithms and their "following feed" under new online safety legislation branded "my feed, my way". The Coalition and right-wing politicians have called the package politically motivated censorship, and AFP reported the government is threatening hefty fines where platforms fail the duty of care. The AFR noted the announcement lands as US technology companies face higher Australian tax bills.

per Reuters: "Australia targets social media algorithms with new user-choice rules" · also Australian Financial Review

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Canberra releases NZYQ deportation agreement with Naoero

The Australian government released the agreement to deport more than 350 refugees and asylum seekers, the "NZYQ cohort", to Naoero, formerly Nauru. Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke said in August 2025 that the deal gave Naoero AU\$2.5 billion over thirty years. Green Party senator David Shoebridge said the release only scratches the surface, that the government "has been far from forthright", and that it continues to resist producing a separate memorandum establishing the financial arrangement.

per RNZ Pacific: "New level of bastardry: Australia releases NZYQ agreement with Naoero"

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Israel warns Canberra against following UK settlement sanctions — Israel's ambassador warned that broad sanctions on settlements would be a deep mistake, as pressure builds on Canberra to match the United Kingdom, France and Canada, which have announced bans on imports from Israeli settlements in the occupied West Bank. The three governments said in a joint statement that rising settler violence poses a "direct and urgent threat" to a two-state solution. Foreign Minister Penny Wong has said Australia is not pursuing a blanket import ban. · The Australian

AU-POLITICS

Foreign network deepfakes dozens of Australian politicians on Facebook — Reset Tech tracked more than 200 Facebook pages impersonating Anthony Albanese, Angus Taylor, Pauline Hanson and other figures over the past eight months, linking the network to an influencer business in Sri Lanka. Roughly 10 percent of the pages have been monetised through Facebook's creator payment scheme. "This isn't foreign interference as we traditionally think of it," said Reset Tech chief research officer Rys Farthing. · ABC News

TRADE-ECONOMY

Economists flag back-to-back rate rises after Hauser warning — Economists moved to forecasts of consecutive increases after Reserve Bank deputy governor Andrew Hauser used a rare television interview to say inflation and growth were both still too high and that the economy is running stronger than expected. The cash rate has been on hold at 4.35 percent since the unanimous decision of 11 August 2026, a second consecutive hold after three increases earlier this year. · AFR

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji says Australia gets no backdoor into new border system

Permanent Secretary for Immigration Aliki Salusalu said Fiji will fully own and operate the Migration Enforcement and Response Intelligence Tool, introduced through the Vuvale Partnership with Australia, when it replaces the Integrated Border Management System next year. "It will be a fully closed system," he said, adding there would be no backdoor access for anyone without the ministry's knowledge.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu launches review of presidential pardon powers

Minister of Justice Job Andy launched the Vanuatu Law Reform Commission report on pardon administration, a review begun in 2020. VLRC principal legal researcher Gracelyn Tasso said the absence of any legislative framework around the President's Article 38 power has produced perceptions of inconsistency and political influence, and left Vanuatu known as the "pardoning capital of the Pacific".

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoa signs US\$3 million ADB-funded vaccine and equipment package

Prime Minister La'aulialemalietao Leuatea Polataivao Fosi Schmidt, acting as Minister of Health, signed for US\$2,965,497 in medical equipment, supplies and specialised trucks under the Asian Development Bank-funded Systems Strengthening for Effective Coverage of New Vaccines in the Pacific project. The project also covers Tonga, Tuvalu and Vanuatu, and UNOPS will run the procurement.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Bank of PNG holds Kina Facility Rate at 5.0 percent

The Bank of Papua New Guinea's Monetary Policy Committee kept the Kina Facility Rate at 5.0 percent and the Cash Reserve Requirement at 9.0 percent following its September 2026 meeting.

TIMOR-LESTE · ABC PACIFIC

Timor-Leste hosts WHO regional committee as malaria-free status draws praise

Health leaders gathered in Timor-Leste for the South East Asia WHO Regional Committee commended the host for becoming malaria free. The same program reported that more than 300 unexploded World War Two ordnances were destroyed on Betio Island in Kiribati over the weekend.

NEW CALEDONIA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

New Caledonia wins French bailout as financial crisis deepens

Islands Business's PACNEWS bulletin reports New Caledonia has secured a French bailout as its financial crisis worsens. The same bulletin carries Japan and UNDP partnering on inclusive elections in Solomon Islands, and Pacific leaders being urged to keep the Bougainville question internal.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji civil society warns on surveillance powers in Police Bill 2026

The Fiji Council of Social Services told Parliament's Standing Committee on Justice, Law and Human Rights that surveillance, tracking and biometric powers in the proposed Fiji Police Bill 2026 could be turned on civil society groups, political opponents and journalists. Programme manager Josaia Tokoni pointed to clauses 57 and 62, a new biometric database, and an offence of causing "disaffection" among police staff that he said could criminalise genuine criticism.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · THE NATIONAL (PNG)

PNG debate turns on whether Bougainville sets a precedent

The National argues Section 276 of the Constitution ensures no province other than Bougainville can pursue the path in Part XIV, which constitutionalised the 2001 Bougainville Peace Agreement. Mt Hagen MP William Duma told Parliament that Section 2 makes the unity of the state absolute. The 2019 referendum returned 97.7 percent for independence.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji Airways opens second Sydney gateway from March 19, 2027

Fiji Airways will fly Nadi to Western Sydney International Airport three times weekly from March 19, 2027, using 737 MAX 8 aircraft and adding about 53,000 seats a year. Chief executive Paul Scurrah said the region is home to one of the largest Fijian communities outside Fiji. The announcement came as Fiji passed one million visitors in a 12-month period for the first time.

NEW ZEALAND

TRADE-ECONOMY · BEEHIVE (NZ GOVT)

Wellington drops royalties on stored gas to unlock storage projects

Resources Minister Shane Jones said the government will end the requirement for developers to pay royalties on gas unlikely to be extracted or sold, removing a barrier to underground storage. Jones said proposals already being explored could significantly expand New Zealand's storage capacity, which he framed as bridging winter and dry-year peaks in electricity demand.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Wellington officials say staffing gaps compromised flood response

Wellington City Council's Civil Defence controller told councillors that a lack of trained emergency operation centre staff compromised the response to the 20 April flash flooding, in which one man died and more than one hundred homes were affected. Emergency management and city development manager Phil Becker said capability at staff level was "very variable" and warned there are not enough skilled people to handle a larger disaster.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

REGIONAL · POLICING COOPERATION · XINHUA STATE MEDIA

Beijing presses for more practical results in Pacific police cooperation

Xinhua reported China called for more practical results with Pacific Island countries in police capacity building and cooperation. The state agency gave no further specifics on countries or programmes in the item carried.

VANUATU · OTHER · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu op-ed answers US deputy secretary of state on the state of the friendship

Responding to an editorial by Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau, the piece acknowledges American wartime infrastructure on Efate and Santo, decades of Peace Corps service, and Millennium Challenge Corporation funding for the Efate Ring Road and Santo East Coast Road. It then lists the complications: unexploded wartime ordnance, the unresolved consequences of American nuclear testing in the Marshall Islands, and US commercial mining interests whose profits leave the region.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Native forest carbon credit scheme splits Greens from environmental groups

A proposed native forest carbon credit scheme has divided the Greens and environmental organisations, presenting an early test for leader Larissa Waters, The Australian reported.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

AFP files top secret evidence seen only by the judge in Avalon hijacking case

The Australian Federal Police has submitted classified material in the Avalon airport hijacking prosecution that will be seen only by the presiding judge, The Australian reported.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

RBA sees slowdown, not recession, from the housing downturn

Reserve Bank assistant governor Sarah Hunter said the housing downturn is hitting related sectors but rejected a developer's warning of recession. The Australian reported separately that analysts have updated forecasts to price declines of up to 15 percent.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

National tax take up 60 percent since Covid to \$893 billion

Combined federal, state and territory tax collections have risen 60 percent since the pandemic to \$893 billion, The Australian reported.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

American money and technology move into Australia's shale patch

US operators are bringing capital, technology and lessons from the American shale boom into Australia's shale acreage, Reuters reported.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Labor's trust tax changes carry a levy on newborns, paper reports

The Australian reports that Labor's proposed changes to trust taxation create an unflagged charge affecting newborn beneficiaries, a detail not set out when the measure was announced.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · BEEHIVE (NZ GOVT)

NZDF and Ngati Rangi sign agreement for 50 homes at Waiouru

Defence Minister Paul Goldsmith announced the New Zealand Defence Force and iwi Ngati Rangi have signed an agreement enabling construction of 50 new homes at Waiouru Military Camp, honouring commitments under the Ngati Rangi Treaty settlement. Buildings and land are sold to the iwi and leased back under a long-term arrangement, with completion expected by mid-2028. Further homes are progressing at Devonport, Wellington, Whenuapai, Christchurch and Manawatu.

"This agreement will strengthen the meaningful partnership NZDF has with Ngāti Rangi, and respects the important role the iwi plays in the future of the land."

CALENDAR WATCH

7 Nov 2026

New Zealand general election, advance voting from 26 October

Decides whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it current defence and Pacific settings.

expected once
negotiations
conclude 2026

Signature of the Australia-Solomon Islands treaty agreed in principle

Canberra has agreed in principle to a billion-dollar package that Honiara's Opposition says is entangled with a failed no-confidence motion.

November to April
2026

Pacific tropical cyclone season

Tonga's meteorological service has been pressing regional media to convert warnings into action before the season opens.

coming months
2026

First application of the Pacific Islands Forum's new dialogue partner model, in New Zealand

Sets the precedent for how the two-tier partner system agreed at Koror handles external powers seeking Forum access.

19 Mar 2027

Fiji Airways begins Nadi to Western Sydney International Airport services

Adds a second Sydney gateway and about 53,000 seats a year to the Australia-Fiji route.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Affirmed, noted, endorsed: Pacific Islands Forum leaders in Koror

Tess Newton Cain and Stefan Armbruster write that a ballistic missile test and China-Taiwan tensions took the headlines, but PIFLM55 in Palau delivered a two-tier dialogue partner system, the Belau Declaration, and commitments on artificial intelligence, gender and renewable energy. · [Devpolicy Blog](#)

PALM welfare support extensive on paper, poorly connected in practice

A Devpolicy policy brief finds the Pacific Australia Labour Mobility welfare system is broad but poorly understood. Approved Employers must provide a Welfare Officer at one full-time equivalent per 120 workers, with the PALM Guidelines 2.1 of 27 March 2026 setting out 56 "must" and four "must not" statements across 11 pages. Because the officer is engaged by the employer, workers may fear that raising a concern jeopardises their job. · [Islands Business](#)

PNG graduates take up UK Chevening scholarships

Top Papua New Guinean university graduates have been awarded Chevening scholarships and travel to the United Kingdom to begin master's study later this month, the Post-Courier reported. · [PNG Post-Courier](#)

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Vanuatu regulator issues revised broadcasting code

The Telecommunications, Radiocommunications and Broadcasting Regulator launched an updated Code of Practice for Broadcasting and Media Services covering fairness, privacy and programme content. Regulator Jesse Benjamin said the revision responds to new platforms and the growth of social media. · [Vanuatu Daily Post](#)

TRADE-ECONOMY

Fiji MPs question sugar subsidies as cane tonnage falls

Standing Committee on Economic Affairs chairperson Sakiusa Tubuna said support to the sugar industry "is not yielding the return", noting that 20 percent of farmers produce 80 percent of cane tonnage while subsidies go to all. Officials said fertiliser subsidies were cut from \$20 million to \$15 million last year without knowing the effect on yields. · [Fiji Sun](#)

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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